discussion of governmental affairs." If the speakers here were not corporations, no one would suggest that the State could silence their proposed speech. It is the type of speech indispensable to decisionmaking in a democracy,[11] and this is no less true because the speech comes from a corporation rather than an individual.[12] The inherent worth of the speech in terms of its capacity for informing the public does not depend upon the identity of its source, whether corporation, association, union, or individual.

The court below nevertheless held that corporate speech is protected by the First Amendment only when it pertains directly to the corporation's business interests. In deciding whether this novel and restrictive gloss on the First Amendment comports with the Constitution and the precedents of this Court, we need not survey the outer boundaries of the Amendment's protection of corporate speech, or address the abstract question whether corporations have the full measure of rights that individuals enjoy under the First Amendment.[13]

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[11] Freedom of expression has particular significance with respect to government because "[i]t is here that the state has a special incentive to repress opposition and often wields a more effective power of suppression." T. Emerson, Toward a General Theory of the First Amendment 9 (1966). See also A. Meiklejohn, Free Speech and Its Relation to Self-Government 24–26 (1948).

[12] The individual's interest in self-expression is a concern of the First Amendment separate from the concern for open and informed discussion, although the two often converge. See G. Gunther, Cases and Materials on Constitutional Law 1044 (9th ed. 1975); T. Emerson, The System of Freedom of Expression 6 (1970). The Court has declared, however, that "speech concerning public affairs is more than self-expression; it is the essence of self-government." *Garrison* v. *Louisiana,* 379 U. S. 64, 74–75 (1964). And self-govenment suffers when those in power suppress competing views on public issues "from diverse and antagonistic sources." *Associated Press* v. *United States,* 326 U. S. 1, 20 (1945), quoted in *New York Times Co.* v. *Sullivan,* 376 U. S. 254, 266 (1964).

[13] Nor is there any occasion to consider in this case whether, under different circumstances, a justification for a restriction on speech that would